

Statement debut: In its ISL opener, Inter Kashi nearly defeated Super Cup champion FC Goa, eventually drawing 1-1 — the first time a newly promoted side earned a point in its league debut.

back.

“The long break, staying at home — if the future is uncertain, how long can a player train?” Passi said. “It’s not easy when you don’t have a deadline,” new signing Alfred Planas Moya said.

“For some months, we actually felt that maybe even after winning the I-League, we might not be able to play in the ISL. Those were very stressful times,” Prithijit added.

The ISL typically starts in September. But the impasse pushed the league well beyond its usual calendar slot.

Several clubs — including Mohun Bagan Super Giant, Kerala Blasters and Odisha FC — suspended first-team operations. Foreign players such as Adrian Luna (loan), Alaaeddine Ajaraie (loan) and Tiri (free transfer), left on loan or permanent transfers.

“It should never happen again. It reflects a lack of professionalism. The players, referees and even coaches have families (to feed). And the public has no football to watch,” Habas says.

“There is such a large population here that there can be three major sports, not just one. I absolutely respect cricket — people in India can love whatever sport they want. But imagine if there had been seven months with no cricket instead of football. It would have been chaos.

“Indian football needs stability and good organisation because pyramids aren’t built from the top down. You build from the bottom up.”

A ray of hope finally appeared when Sports Minister Mansukh Mandaviya announced that the league would go ahead.

“In December-January, the Federation worked overnight. The ISL interim committee worked through Christmas and found a solution. On February 14 — Valentine’s Day — for the love of



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football, it started again,” Prithijit says.

Habas’s step down to the I-League had allowed him to test the waters across both tiers. So did his players. In its ISL opener, the team nearly defeated Super Cup champion FC Goa, eventually drawing 1-1 — the first time a newly promoted side earned a point in its

league debut. “We have mutual respect for all teams, but we will not be scared of any team,” said Planas.

“We’re not setting long-term targets. We’re taking it one game at a time,” Habas adds. “That has to be our reality. Above all, we must keep competing and build a solid team for the future.”

Title validates ambition; home